

Cycling for Arthritis: Benefits, Tips and Getting Started

Complete UK guide to cycling with arthritis. Learn about benefits for knee and hip joints, choosing the right bike, e-bikes and safe riding tips for joint pain.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Pending clinical review ·
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*Person cycling on a stationary bike for gentle arthritis exercise in a bright room
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Cycling is one of the most highly recommended forms of exercise for people with arthritis, particularly those with knee and hip osteoarthritis. As a low-impact activity that builds strength, improves cardiovascular fitness and enhances joint mobility without

the jarring impact of running or high-impact sports, cycling offers a uniquely arthritis-friendly way to stay active. In the UK, the growth of cycle paths, e-bike availability and indoor cycling options means there has never been a better time to start pedalling for your joint health. This guide covers everything from the science behind cycling's benefits to practical advice on choosing the right bike and riding safely with arthritis.

Why Cycling Is Excellent for Arthritis

Low Impact, High Benefit

Unlike running or walking, cycling is a non-weight-bearing exercise. Your body weight is supported by the saddle, eliminating the ground-reaction forces that can aggravate arthritic joints. This makes cycling accessible even for people who find walking painful. Research in *Journal of Rheumatology* shows that cycling produces significantly less joint loading than walking while providing comparable cardiovascular and muscular benefits.

Strengthens Supporting Muscles

Cycling powerfully strengthens the quadriceps, hamstrings, glutes and calf muscles — the key muscle groups that support and stabilise the knee and hip joints. Stronger muscles absorb more of the forces that would otherwise be transmitted to joint cartilage. A 12-week cycling programme for knee OA patients showed a 30% improvement in quadricep strength and a significant reduction in pain scores.

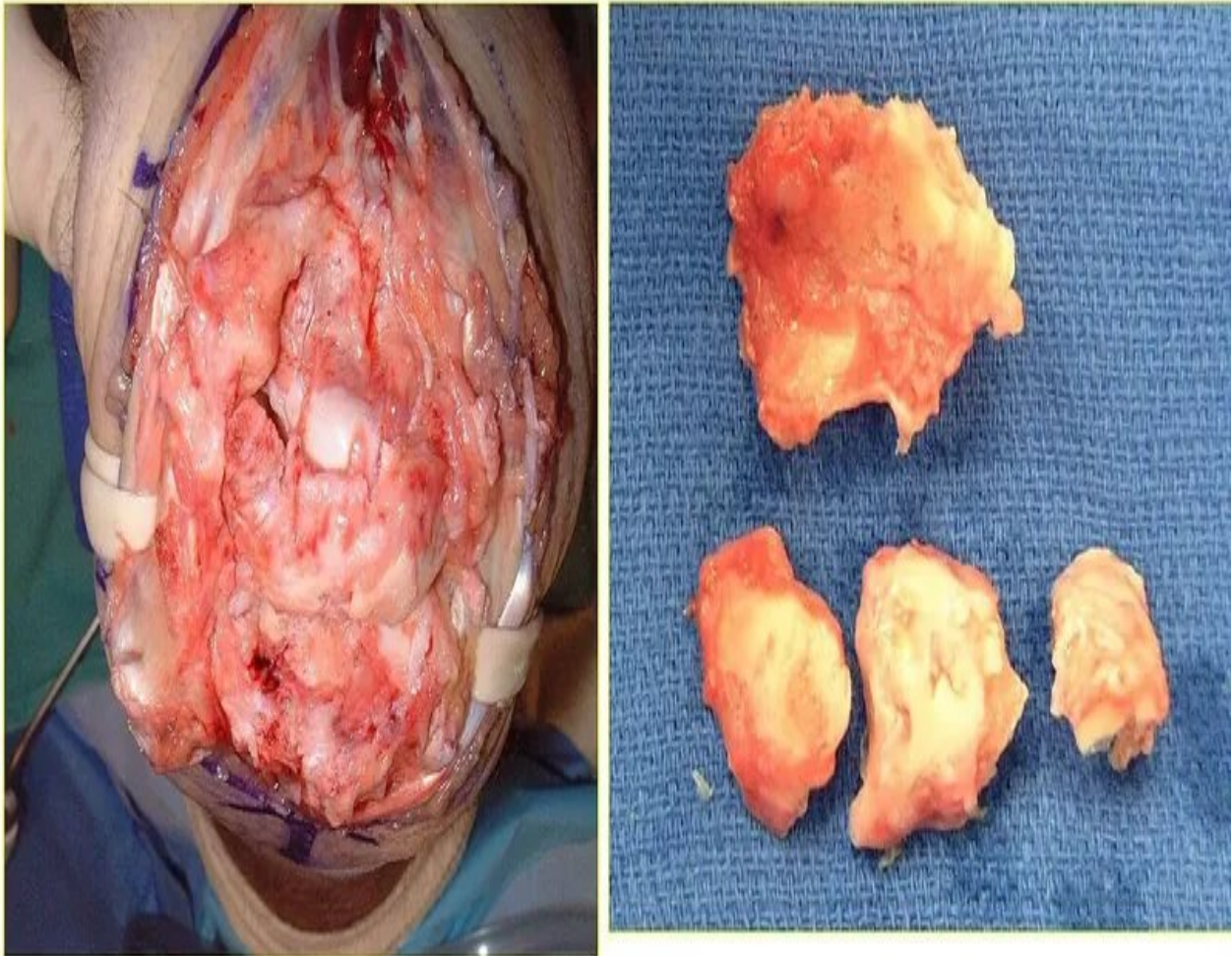
Improves Joint Range of Motion

The smooth, circular pedalling motion takes the knee through a controlled range of approximately 70–110 degrees of flexion with each revolution. This repetitive, gentle movement helps maintain and even improve joint mobility while stimulating the production and distribution of synovial fluid — the natural lubricant within joints.

Cardiovascular and Mental Health

Cycling is an effective cardiovascular exercise that helps manage weight, reduce blood pressure and improve heart health — all important for arthritis patients who may be at increased cardiovascular risk. The outdoor variety also provides mood-boosting benefits through fresh air, scenery and a sense of independence and achievement.

Choosing the Right Bike



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Stationary Bikes (Indoor)

An excellent starting point, especially for those new to cycling or with significant joint limitations:

- Upright exercise bikes — Mimic outdoor cycling position. Good for general fitness. Available at most UK gyms and leisure centres
- Recumbent bikes — A reclined seating position with back support. Reduces strain on hands, wrists and lower back. Often recommended by physiotherapists for hip and knee arthritis
- Home options — Basic exercise bikes start from around £100–£200 at retailers like Argos, Decathlon and Amazon UK. Higher-end models with interactive screens (Peloton,

Wattbike) offer guided classes

E-Bikes (Electric-Assist)

E-bikes have transformed cycling for people with arthritis in the UK. The electric motor provides assistance when you need it — on hills, into headwinds or when fatigue sets in — while still requiring you to pedal and exercise. Key benefits include the ability to ride further with less fatigue, to tackle hills without excessive joint strain, and to adjust the assistance level to match how your joints feel on any given day. Prices in the UK range from around £800 for basic models to £3,000+ for premium brands. Many UK cycle shops offer test rides. The government's Cycle to Work scheme can provide tax savings on e-bike purchases.

Standard Bikes

For those with milder arthritis, a standard bicycle works well. Hybrid bikes (a cross between road and mountain bikes) offer a comfortable, upright riding position with wider tyres for stability. Key setup considerations include ensuring the saddle height is correct (your knee should have a slight bend at the bottom of the pedal stroke — about 25–35 degrees), using flat pedals rather than clipless until you're confident, and considering wider, cushioned saddles for comfort.

Getting Started: A 6-Week Beginner Plan

Weeks 1–2: Familiarisation

Start with 10–15 minutes of gentle cycling at very low resistance on a stationary bike. Pedal at a comfortable cadence (around 60–70 RPM). Focus on smooth, pain-free pedalling. Ride 3 times per week with rest days between sessions.

Weeks 3–4: Building Duration

Increase to 20 minutes per session. Add a small amount of resistance if comfortable. If cycling outdoors, start with flat, quiet routes. Continue 3 times per week.

Weeks 5–6: Progressing

Aim for 25–30 minutes per session. Introduce gentle variations — slight resistance changes, brief intervals of slightly faster pedalling. Consider adding a fourth session if recovery is good. By the end of week 6, most people notice meaningful improvements in joint stiffness, leg strength and overall energy.

Safety Tips for Cycling with Arthritis



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- Warm up — Pedal gently for 5 minutes with no resistance before increasing intensity
- Low resistance is key — High gear/resistance increases force through the knee. Use lower gears and higher cadence (spinning faster with less resistance)
- Don't push through sharp pain — Mild discomfort is normal; sharp or increasing pain means stop
- Adjust your bike properly — A professional bike fit (available at most UK cycle shops for £50–£150) is highly recommended. Poor setup can worsen joint problems
- Wear a helmet — Always, regardless of distance or speed
- Visibility — Use lights and high-visibility clothing, especially during UK winter months

- Listen to your joints — Some days will be better than others. Adjust your ride accordingly
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Cycling Resources in the UK

- Cycling UK (cyclinguk.org) — Britain's national cycling charity, offering route planning, group rides and cycling holiday information
- British Cycling — Offers Breeze rides (women-only), guided rides for beginners and accessible cycling programmes
- Sustrans — Manages the National Cycle Network with over 12,000 miles of routes across the UK, many traffic-free
- Local cycling groups — Many areas have gentle or social cycling clubs suitable for all abilities
- Wheels for All — Provides inclusive cycling sessions using adapted cycles for people with disabilities, including hand-cycles and trikes

Cycling offers a perfect combination of joint-friendly exercise, independence and enjoyment. Whether you choose a stationary bike in your living room, an e-bike for weekend adventures or a gentle spin around your local park, every pedal stroke brings benefits for your joints and overall health. Try our virtual assistant for personalised cycling advice for your specific joints.

This article is for general information only. Consult your GP or physiotherapist before starting a new exercise programme.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about cycling for arthritis uk: benefits, tips and getting started?

Short answer: Cycling is highly recommended for arthritis, especially for knee and hip osteoarthritis, as it is a low-impact exercise. It strengthens supporting muscles like quadriceps, glutes, and hamstrings, while improving joint range of motion through gentle, repetitive pedalling. Stationary bikes, e-bikes, and standard bikes are suitable options. Begin with 10–15 minutes of gentle cycling, three times a week, gradually increasing duration and resistance.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk